

CLASSIFIED FAITH
Pilgrims bathe in the Gandek river near Patna

old ones will be critical for a state that elects 40 members to the Lok Sabha.

For the BJP, which derives electoral strength from the homogeneity of the Hindus, playing the caste card is not too advantageous. On the other hand, the caste count should come as oxygen for consummate practitioners of the game such as Nitish, Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) patron Lalu Yadav and other regional players.

While the RJD—which relies on the Yadav-Muslim axis—had failed to win a single Lok Sabha seat in the 2019 general election, Nitish's JD(U) had performed much below expectations in the 2020 assembly polls, winning just 43 of the 115 seats it contested. Clearly, both parties need to revive their caste magic in Bihar. While Nitish has the 30 per cent extremely backward castes (EBCs) and 10 per cent Mahadalits as his core voters, Lalu and son Tejashwi, the RJD chief, have the backing of 14 per cent Yadavs and 18 per cent Muslims. Recent election results, though, suggest that the core vote is slipping from their grasp.

THE BIHAR CASTE CENSUS RESULTS COULD LEAD TO A SOCIAL CHURN, AFFECTING THE 2024 LS POLL OUTCOME

If the census outcome stirs the caste cauldron again, they are likely to consolidate and rally behind their political champions again, which will suit both Lalu and Nitish. For the BJP, which has gained at the expense of the two regional powers in Bihar, it will be a challenge to beat them at the caste game.

Over the years, the BJP has largely used a Plan B, combining legacy politics (like describing King Ashoka as a Kushwaha caste leader) and Hindutva slogans, but the caste count can throw up an entirely new set of challenges.

"It is not difficult to understand why the JD(U) and RJD, parties that claim to represent the marginalised communities, are the biggest proponents of the caste census. This will help them strengthen their identity politics whereas a party like the BJP, which is often accused of religious polarisation, may be weakened," says Dr Nawal Kishore Choudhary, retired head of the economics department, Patna University. But a senior BJP leader disagrees. "Let's not forget that Prime Minister Narendra Modi has successfully stamped his OBC origins on the poll discourse. We have crunched the Mandal numbers successfully in UP and there is no reason why we cannot do this in Bihar," he says.

Over the years, Nitish has emerged as the biggest proponent of a caste census, even leading an all-party delegation to meet Modi on the issue. And he is technically correct, for caste-based reservation is already a settled issue in India. As a senior IAS officer puts it, "The OBCs—like the other communities—don't really form a homogenous bloc and nor are they equally deprived. Data from the caste count will help map the economic and social backgrounds of the population, which in turn will help the state offset the disadvantages of those left at the bottom of the social pyramid." This is why the JD(U) wants a sub-categorisation of the OBCs and equitable redistribution of their quota.

Nitish understands the value of a more focused 'positive discrimination' in favour of the neediest ones. Bihar follows a system where reservation for the backward castes is divided into two categories —EBCs and OBCs. The Centre provides 27 per cent reservation to the OBCs whereas Bihar follows a system where OBCs get 12 per cent reservation, EBCs 18 per cent and women of backward classes 3 per cent.

That said, Bihar's caste-based census could trigger similar decisions in other states, something that may impact all walks of politics and governance in India. There have been arguments in favour of apportioning all opportunities under the state solely in proportion to the strength of communities, but there are questions of values as well. For instance, won't such allocation seal the fate for open competition and the longer term goal of a caste-free society? There are no easy answers. ■